

Tom Lindley . . .

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hasn't been sentenced to a lifetime of suffering. There are explanations for some of the present inadequacies and solutions on the way regarding the others.

As explained by UTEP Athletic Director Jim Bowden, the Miners are playing with broken bats because the new bats on order haven't arrived from the manufacturer. They are playing with taped balls simply because the new pitching machine the squad has acquired has by agreement with the El Paso Diablos, UTEP has agreed not to play on Dudley Field until later in the season, thereby allowing the grass to grow so as to make the park presentable.

The players, however, have had a hard time accepting some of the facts. But then a lot of fans had difficulty accepting the fact that Babe Ruth's homerun record was broken, too.

"Every game will be a road trip for us," said one player when told that the Miners would be dividing their home games between Dudley Field and the Ysleta cut-off field and practicing at yet another field, Hugo Meyer. "We'll have to stay at Motel 6."

In actuality, a new baseball park is in the works for the Miners. It is to be built on campus. The reason construction hasn't started is that contractors are using part of the site on which to store heavy equipment while they construct an academic building on campus.

The pride the Miner baseball players have left, however, is what is making them defensive. They're afraid that the lifeguard who's sitting up there under the big umbrella can't count all that well and that before he knows it they will have gone under for the third time.

"EVERYONE WANTS US to do good but they don't give Andy

(baseball coach Andy Cohen) the money to recruit or run a good program," said one player. "He doesn't have the money to recruit. Most of the players do come from out of state but they are signed through personal contacts with Andy. He has friends in baseball who tell him about us. Coach Cohen never saw me play. He had to take a recommendation from a friend that I was a player."

Admittedly, the baseball program is alive today but for the dedication of Andy Cohen. The long-time baseball man does receive some payment for his services from the university but it is a small sum in comparison to what UTEP would have to pay to employ a fulltime coach.

"Right now we couldn't afford to pay somebody what schools like Arizona State pay their baseball coaches," Bowden said. "That may change in the future. It might change as fast as next year. Since baseball can't pay its won way, what will determine our future plans is how well we draw in football in basketball. And I'm optimistic that football will draw well this season."

Although baseball is the national pastime and all that and it's true that Johnny Bench will need replacing one day, that isn't to say there is an urgent need to keep the factory open at UTEP.

While the Miner baseball team does attract some sun bathers and folks who like to surround themselves with empty seats to their games, interest in UTEP baseball isn't great. It's not THE social event of the day. For those reasons, the UTEP baseball team doesn't deserve to be spoiled.

But if the situation as it now exists continues, the public is going to have to be more tolerant of the Miner baseball team. After all, it is difficult to lay down a suicide squeeze bunt using the short end of the stick.